Huawei plays a dominant role in African telecommunications systems, and the company's employees have been reported to have helped repressive governments in Uganda and Zambia track political opponents, including by intercepting their communications.[35]

Uncertainty about the extent of Huawei's ties to the PLA and Chinese intelligence services has further raised suspicions about its use by official Chinese actors. China's 2017 National Intelligence Law also requires Chinese companies and individuals "to provide access, cooperation, or support for Beijing's intelligence-gathering activities," as recounted by one report.[36] Given such concerns, the Trump administration banned the company from participating in the building of America's 5G networks, while governments ranging from Canada to Japan and New Zealand similarly blocked Huawei's 5G technology. Others, however, including many in Europe, either decided to allow Huawei access to their 5G networks or postponed decisions while balancing Chinese pressure with security concerns.

China's military has similarly benefited from Beijing's traditional and cyber espionage. When the PLA Air Force made a surprise maiden flight of the country's first stealth fighter, the J-20, during the visit of then secretary of defense Robert Gates to Beijing in January 2011, the diplomatic awkwardness was paralleled by the commentary on the uncanny similarities between the Chinese prototype and the American-made F-22 Raptor.[37] Two years after pictures of the J-20 were revealed, the US Defense Department acknowledged that nearly every American military weapons development program had been infiltrated by Chinese hackers, thus helping to explain why Chinese advanced fighters and drones looked like copies of American versions.[38] Such defense industrial espionage means that US taxpayers are in essence subsidizing the development of the Chinese military.

Despite promises by Chinese president Xi Jinping to Barack Obama in 2015 to halt such predatory practices against American companies and citizens, there has been no letup in Chinese cyber aggressiveness. Such unprecedented attacks on private individuals of another nation go far beyond the type of cyber influence campaigns run by Russia that